

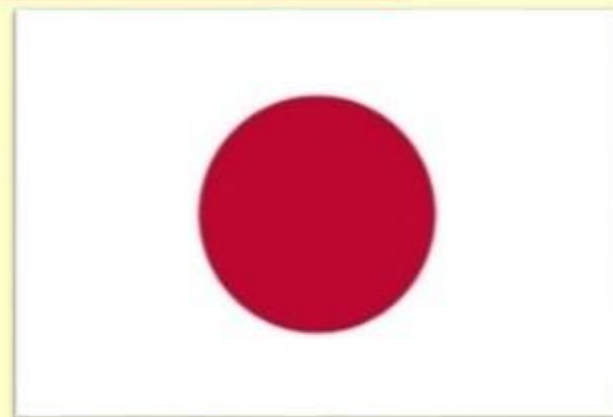
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NEWSPAPER 18th September, 2017

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

38th WEEK



INDIA-JAPAN... JOINT STATEMENT

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II... BILATERAL AGREEMENTS INVOLVING INDIA AND AFFECTING INDIA'S INTERESTS.



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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS ... DISCUSSION

18th SEPTEMBER, 2017

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The arc to Tokyo

India and Japan are infusing bilateral ties with a sharper geopolitical agenda

Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe's visit to India, part of annual summits between the two countries, has set strategic ties on a fast track. This is best symbolised by the Ahmedabad-Mumbai bullet train project that was launched by Mr. Abe and Prime Minister Narendra Modi. India's decision to partner with Japan for the 508-km, ₹1.1 lakh-crore project is as much about politics as it is about infrastructure: Japan has been keen to export its high-speed train technology along with rolling stock, and India's move to confirm the Japanese contracts while China wins projects along its Belt and Road railway line is significant. The joint statement and comments by the two Prime Ministers in Gandhinagar also sent out a similar message that will be read closely in China on several counts. For example, Mr. Abe said North Korea was a "joint" challenge for India and Japan, and the statement contained a phrase about holding countries "that have supported North Korea's nuclear and missile programmes" accountable, obviously aimed at Pyongyang's benefactors in Beijing. The clause calling for zero tolerance on terrorism referenced China's veto on the Jaish-e-Mohammad chief being put on the list of UN-designated terrorists. Both the title of the joint statement, "Toward a free, open and prosperous Indo-Pacific", and substantive paragraphs on cooperation in the region, indicate a much closer alignment between India and Japan in countering China's influence in the South China Sea, its forays into the Indian Ocean, and investments in South Asia and Africa. The coming into force of the India-Japan nuclear deal and more military and maritime exercises will buttress such efforts. India has also extended to Japan an offer denied to any other country, which is to assist in infrastructure development in the Northeast.

It is clear that the Modi government has set India-Japan ties on an accelerated geopolitical course that will be a major factor in its dealings with the rest of the world, especially China, at a time when the U.S. is perceived to be retreating from the region. Having made this leap, it is imperative that India and Japan also look beyond their lofty geopolitical aims, at the more basic aspects of bilateral engagement. While Japan is India's largest donor and the third largest provider of FDI, bilateral trade has steadily declined since 2013, and is down to \$13.61 billion in 2016-17 from \$14.51 billion the year before. The contrast with India-China trade, at \$71 billion a year, and Japan-China trade, at \$279 billion, is stark, and the decision to finalise four new locations for special Japanese industrial townships may be only one way of addressing the difficulties businessmen face in India. With the opulent pagantry and 8-km roadshow in Gujarat over, it is time to get down to brass tacks and address some of the issues in order to facilitate closer ties between India and Japan, even as the two leaders and militaries forge closer bonds.

2 The arc to Tokyo

Date : 16th September, 2017

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2 The arc to Tokyo

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Date : 16th September, 2017

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IMPORTANT QUESTIONS?

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

The Joint Statement and financial assistance on easiest terms for bullet train project symbolizes a new era in India Japan relations. Critically examine.



NEWS REPORT

- 1 India-Japan Annual Summit was held in Ahmedabad.
- 2 This is symbolised by Ahmedabad-Mumbai bullet train project.
- 3 Japan is keen to export its high-speed train technology along with rolling stock and this is the significant development.
- 4 It is mutually beneficial for both the Countries.



THE INDIA-JAPAN ANNUAL SUMMIT AND THE JOINT STATEMENT



POINT NO- 1

STATEMENT

- Mr. Abe said North Korea was a Joint Challenge for India and Japan, and the Statement also contained a phrase about holding countries “that have supported North Korea’s Nuclear and Missile Programmes” accountable.



INFERENCE

- This infers clearly that the Statement aims at Pyongyang’s benefactors in Beijing. That means the Statement indirectly refers to China.





THE INDIA-JAPAN ANNUAL SUMMIT AND THE JOINT STATEMENT



POINT NO: 2

STATEMENT

- The clause is also there calling for **zero tolerance on Terrorism**.



INFERENCE

- This can be inferred as indirect reference to **China's veto on the Jaish-e-Mohammad Chief being put on the list of UN-designated terrorists**.





THE INDIA-JAPAN ANNUAL SUMMIT AND THE JOINT STATEMENT



POINT NO: 3

STATEMENT

- Both the title of the Joint Statement, “Towards a free, open and prosperous Indo-Pacific”, as well as substantive paragraphs on co-operation in the region signifies much more.



INFERENCE

- They indicate a much closer alignment between India and Japan in countering China's influence in the South China Sea, its forays into the Indian Ocean, and investments in South Asia and Africa.

OTHER ASPECTS WHICH HAVE SIGNIFICANCE

- 1** India-Japan nuclear deal came into force and now the Summit signalled more military and maritime exercises to buttress the efforts of China in South China Sea as well as in Indian Ocean region.
- 2** India extended an offer to Japan to assist in the Infrastructure Development in North-East, which was denied to any other Country.
- 3** Now U.S. is perceived to be retreating from the region and hence the accelerated pace of India-Japan ties assumed significance from the Geo-Political perspective also.
- 4** Japan is India's largest donor and third largest provider of FDI.

BUT LOW ON TRADE...

- 1** The bilateral trade steadily declined since 2013, and at present stands at around \$ 13.6 billion in 2016-17, in comparison to \$ 14.5 billion the year before.
- 2** India-China trade is at around \$ 71 billion and Japan-China trade is \$ 279 billion.

The decision to finalize four new locations for special Japanese industrial townships may be only one way of addressing the difficulties businessmen face in India, and the need of the hour is to ensure faster and closer-ties between India and Japan.

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